male colleagues from the DP.' They claim the public space and get agency, and also work outside the home.[151] In many ways, the BJP's focus on the mobilisation of women is informed by this broad worldview.

The Sabarimala Conundrum: Tradition Vis-à-vis Women's Equality

The BJP's decision, in 2018, to oppose the Supreme Court's decision on opening up the Sabarimala Ayyappa shrine in Kerala to women of menstruating age illustrated the tensions between its new outreach to women and the older cultural notions it was moved by. BJP President Amit Shah declared that the apex court should desist from passing judgements that could not be enforced. The party, he said, stood on the side of Ayyappa devotees, framing the conflict as a battle for 'dharma, belief and bhakti'.[152] When Prime Minister Modi was asked why the BJP supported the criminalisation of triple talaq among Muslims but was opposing the entry of Hindu women into Sabarimala, he answered that triple talaq was a matter of gender equality, while Sabarimala was one of tradition. He told ANI that many 'Islamic countries', including Pakistan, had banned triple talaq and, therefore, it was 'not an issue of religion or belief'. On Sabarimala, conversely, he insisted that 'India is of the view that everyone should get equal rights' and pointed to diverse traditions: 'In India, there are also some small temples where men cannot go and men do not go.' Pointing to the one dissenting note, by Justice Indu Malhotra, in the 5–1 Supreme Court Sabarimala ruling, the prime minister said, 'a woman judge in the Supreme Court has made certain observations. It needs to be read minutely. She has seen the issue as a woman also and given her views. There should be a debate on that as well sometimes.'[153] Shah too insisted that the limitation on entry was 'not discrimination', it was 'part of worship' and about the 'protection of the uniqueness' of the Sabarimala shrine, the only Ayyappa temple that had restrictions on women because of the celibate form of the deity there.[154]